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Democracy Dies in Darkness

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Zelensky’s top aide, key envoy resigns

Andriy Yermak’s home, office searched as corruption probe widens

BY SIOBHÁN O’GRADY AND KOSTIANTYN KHUDOV

KYIV — Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelensky’s top aide and closest confidant — who also served as lead negotiator in talks with U.S. officials to reach a peace plan to end Russia’s war — resigned Friday, hours after authorities searched his home and office amid a widening corruption probe.

Andriy Yermak, 54, chief of staff for Zelensky, returned just days ago from Geneva, where he met with U.S. Secretary of State Marco Rubio and other top officials to urge a rewrite of a controversial peace plan the White House was pushing on Ukraine by Thanksgiving, saying Kyiv risked losing all U.S. support.

The external pressure rose as Ukraine’s anti-corruption officials exposed a major scandal involving significant kickbacks from Ukraine’s energy and defense sectors — the two most sensitive areas for the Ukrainian public as the war rages and power cuts leave cities engulfed in darkness for much of each day.

Investigators have not yet said what the reason was for Friday’s search, but the appearance was enough to force Yermak out.

His abrupt resignation marks the most significant shake-up in Zelensky’s office since the war began, signaling both the seriousness of the probe and mounting fears in Ukraine that Washington or Moscow might leverage the scandal at the negotiating table.

U.S. officials are set to return to SEE UKRAINE ON A11

For active minds, age may be just a number

New research suggests creative hobbies could slow down brain aging

BY MEERI KIM

Playing music, dancing, creating art — and even playing some types of video games — aren’t just immersive and emotionally rewarding. They may actually slow down brain aging, a new study suggests. By analyzing brain activity data, the researchers found that engaging in creative pursuits of all kinds is linked to a younger-looking brain. The study was published by Nature Communications in October.

“This is not just a solution for the da Vincis of the world. Anyone can benefit from having a creative hobby, not just geniuses or professional artists,” said study author Agustín Ibáñez, director of the Latin American Brain Health Institute at Universidad Adolfo Ibáñez. “We are living in a world full of stress, uncertainty and despair. Creating a little bubble through art or music can have a positive impact on your brain health.”

SEE HOBBIES ON A2



DEMETRIUS FREEMAN/THE WASHINGTON POST

National Guard members patrol Friday in downtown Washington. Charges were upgraded after the death of Spec. Sarah Beckstrom.

Afghan suspect was vetted before entering U.S.

This article is by Mariana Alfaro, Karen DeYoung, Arelis R. Hernández, Jeremy Roebuck and Warren P. Strobel

The Afghan national accused of shooting two National Guard members near the White House this week underwent thorough vetting by counterterrorism authorities before entering the United States, according to people with direct knowledge of the case.

Rahmanullah Lakanwal, 29, arrived in the U.S. through Operation Allies Welcome (OAW), a Biden-era program that helped resettle Afghan nationals after

He arrived in 2021 under Biden-era program after wartime duty in CIA unit

the U.S. military withdrawal from Afghanistan in 2021.

The shooting has brought immediate scrutiny to that and other programs, with President Donald Trump announcing plans for a full review of those admitted and immigration officials halting the processing of requests from anyone from Afghanistan. In addition, Homeland Security Secretary

Kristi L. Noem and other senior Trump officials claimed, without evidence, that Lakanwal was never vetted and laid blame for his presence in the U.S. on former president Joe Biden.

The security of Afghan resettlement programs under the Biden administration has been a politically fraught issue for several years, stemming in part from the hasty and chaotic U.S. evacuation effort after the fall of the Afghan government to the Taliban.

A key question from critics has been whether any evacuees managed to enter the U.S. without proper vetting. Lakanwal, however, would not have been among

them, according to the individuals, who spoke on the condition of anonymity because of the sensitivity of the investigation. One of the individuals said Lakanwal was vetted years ago, before working with the CIA in Afghanistan, and then again before he arrived in the U.S. in 2021. Those SEE IMMIGRATION ON A7

Slain victim: Sorrow and dismay in Guard troop’s W.Va. hometown. A5

Granted asylum: Suspect’s work in Kandahar earned U.S. ticket. A7

D.C. patrols: City police will join military and give assistance. B13

Hegseth order on first boat strike, officials say: Kill them all

BY ALEX HORTON AND ELLEN NAKASHIMA

The longer the U.S. surveillance aircraft followed the boat, the more confident intelligence analysts watching from command centers became that the 11 people on board were ferrying drugs.

Defense Secretary Pete Hegseth gave a spoken directive, according to two people with direct

Commander followed defense chief’s order to leave no survivors

knowledge of the operation. “The order was to kill everybody,” one of them said.

A missile screamed off the Trin-

idad coast, striking the vessel and igniting a blaze from bow to stern. For minutes, commanders watched the boat burning on a live drone feed. As the smoke cleared, they got a jolt: Two survivors were clinging to the smoldering wreck.

The Special Operations commander overseeing the Sept. 2 attack — the opening salvo in the Trump administration’s war on suspected drug traffickers in the

Western Hemisphere — ordered a second strike to comply with Hegseth’s instructions, two people familiar with the matter said. The two men were blown apart in the water.

Hegseth’s order, which has not been previously reported, adds another dimension to the campaign against suspected drug traffickers. Some current and former U.S. officials and law-of-war ex-

perts have said that the Pentagon’s lethal campaign — which has killed more than 80 people to date — is unlawful and may expose those most directly involved to future prosecution.

The alleged traffickers pose no imminent threat of attack against the United States and are not, as the Trump administration has tried to argue, in an “armed con-

SEE STRIKE ON A8

Wyo. fair grapples with plight over pig wrestling

Some in the community say the event is cruel, but the tradition will return — with no men allowed

BY ANUMITA KAUR

Wyoming county fair is bringing back pig wrestling after a six-year hiatus, though it’s adding a new rule: No men allowed.

The ban is meant to protect the swine after concerns about animal cruelty rippled through Teton County this fall and pleas for humane treatment of the animals surged into county commissioners’ email inboxes.

The commissioners struck a compromise by voting 3-1 last week to eliminate the adult men’s category of the game and require participants to complete a program about caring for animals. Mark Newcomb, Teton County

commission chairman, said commissioners surmised that women and children would be less likely than men to harm the pigs. (The only woman commissioner was absent from the vote.)

Still, Newcomb said, it’s an imperfect solution.

“I think there are men and women, older than 18, and even folks who might be transitioning either way, who are plenty strong, plenty athletic,” he said.

County commissioners and residents during a meeting last week spent nearly 90 minutes debating whether the decades-long community tradition belongs in the modern fair. Proponents said the sport’s popularity SEE WRESTLING ON A2



AMBER BAESLER/JACKSON HOLE NEWS & GUIDE

Peewee division pig wrestlers Oliver Sternberg, Adger Sternberg, Reifel Hall and Jack McNamara run after a swine during a match at the Teton County Fair in 2018.

IN THE NEWS

Fury in Hong Kong The fire that blazed through a cramped apartment complex and killed more than 100 people has become a test for the city’s Beijing-backed leaders. A11

Israeli forces face probe TV footage shows two Palestinian men in the West Bank being fatally shot after appearing to surrender. A10

THE NATION New flight rules at Mar-a-Lago are causing endless plane noise for neighbors. A3
An attack on a Chicago commuter train renewed Trump’s opposition to cashless bail. A4

THE WORLD Pope Leo XIV prayed at Turkey’s Lake Iznik, whose waters are under threat. A9
An Israeli military assault on a town in southern Syria killed at least 13 residents. A10

THE ECONOMY Retail sites Temu and Shein have defied predictions of doom that followed the implementation of Trump’s tariffs, with shopper interest rebounding amid a dip in U.S. sales this year, a trend that affirms Americans’ love of cheap Chinese stuff. A14

STYLE The Playstation 5, introduced 5 years ago, has plateaued, but it hasn’t declined. B1

SPORTS Kevin Blackstone writes that a 40-year-old college sophomore is still running after 20 years in the Army. B7

THE REGION Adams Morgan’s neighborhood listserv remains a place where everybody knows your rant but not necessarily your (real) name. B13
A rat and rodent infestation of an apartment tower in Silver Spring has prompted a buildingwide inspection. B13

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